

Brand Bharat

Hardselling the Indian wonder

| By Dilip Bobb |

At the peak of the UK *Big Brother* row over the late Jade Goody's crude remarks on Indians, the India Tourism office sent her a letter published in leading UK newspapers inviting her and her friends to India as guests to experience the country and culture. It represented a dramatic change in the bureaucratic mindset. It was a sophisticated way of putting Goody in her place and also symbolic of how a group of officials in the tourism ministry, led by the author, had changed the rules of the bureaucratic game with their 2002 'Incredible India' campaign. It was a global brand building exercise to create a definable country profile of modern India that combined style, sophistication, creativity, humour and professionalism, the very antithesis of officialdom. Dominating New York's Times Square was a huge billboard showing a Bengal tiger with the caption: "Not all Indians are polite, hospitable and vegetarian." Similarly, clever slogans with stunning visuals adorned buses, taxis and prominent buildings in key world cities. This book is about Indian tourism, but it is also the story of a branding exercise that has become a pop culture icon. Amitabh Kant was the brains behind Kerala's successful "God's Own

Country' campaign that switched focus from mass market budget travellers to high-end tourists with remarkable results. This is a story on what dynamic bureaucrats can do given a free hand, but also a cautionary tale, one that India's new tourism minister would do well to add to her library. ■



**BRANDING INDIA:
AN INCREDIBLE
STORY**

by AMITABH KANT
Collins Business
Price: Rs 499
Pages: 267



SAURABH SINGH

Mystery of the Senses

A tale of desperate love set in the exotic East

| By Bunny Suraiya |



**BREATHING
IN COLOUR**
by CLARE JAY
Piatkus
Price: Rs 295
Pages: 280

Synaesthesia is "a union of the senses... a sensory condition in which textures might be tasted on the tongue, or musical notes experienced in colours". Despite the fact that only one in 25,000 people has the condition, it is a handy device for Clare Jay in her debut novel, affording her an opportunity to juxtapose imagery in an original and inventive manner. Alida and Ian Salter's daughter, Mia, is a synaesthete whose father has "a baked potato voice", whose mother's anger causes "everything to smell of asparagus", and who dreads "the burned-onion taste of (her) parents' shouting".

Mia's condition could be the cause of The Thing that happened to their family when she was six years old and which has resulted in the family breaking up. The Thing is mentioned repeatedly, but it is not until the middle of the book that it becomes clear what it was; and then the revelation gives rise to the new riddle of what exactly caused The Thing to happen. These two mysteries are at the core of the narrative, which begins with a phone call to Alida from a police station in Madurai, informing her that Mia, 18 years old and backpacking in India, has gone missing. Alida rushes to India to search for her daughter, finding in Mia's hotel room a set of disturbing collages that bring back the past, The Thing, that continues to haunt both mother and daughter, and which has fragmented their relationship. But the collages could also be messages from Mia to her mother, perhaps pointing the way to a future where their relationship could be redeemed—if Mia is still alive.

The "mystique" of India as seen through a backpacking Westerner's eyes complements the mysteries in the tale, though it suffers from repetition in the telling (heat, beggars, colour, sweat and mosquitoes are evoked endlessly) and could have been more stringently edited to make for a tauter tale. ■